

07

Headline Formulas and the Swipe File

Document 7 of 9

If you're new to this series, start with ****What a Headline Actually Does****.

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Formulas Are Training Wheels, Not the Bike

The internet is full of lists — "283 headline templates," "100+ fill-in-the-blank formulas." They exist because formulas genuinely work: each one is the fossil of a psychological pattern that pulled response for decades, compressed into a reusable shape. But copy your formulas mechanically and your headlines will read mechanically, because the reader has seen the skeleton before too.

The right relationship with formulas is the one a musician has with scales. You practice them until the *patterns underneath* — the benefit promise, the curiosity gap, the warning, the proof signal — become instinct. Then you stop playing scales in public. A formula is a starting scaffold for a draft and a diagnostic lens for reading great ads, never a finished headline.

This document gives you the small set of master formulas worth internalizing, teaches you *why* each works (so you can bend it), and shows you how to build the tool that eventually replaces all lists: your own swipe file.

The Master Formulas

1. How to [Achieve Desirable Outcome]. The most durable opening in advertising. "How to" makes an implicit contract: read this, and you'll come away *able to do something you couldn't before*. It converts a claim into an offer of instruction — nobody argues with a lesson. Strengthen it by attaching the benefit's edges: "How to Win Friends and Influence People" (the title Dale Carnegie made famous) works because both halves are things the reader deeply wants and privately doubts they're good at. Variants: "How to [outcome] without [dreaded cost]," "How to [outcome] even if [disqualifier]."

2. Who Else Wants [Desirable Outcome]? The hidden engine is the word *else* — it presupposes a crowd already getting the outcome, so the headline is simultaneously a benefit promise and social proof. "Who Else Wants a Screen-Star Figure?" isn't asking whether the outcome is possible; that's settled. It's only asking whether *you're* joining.

3. [Do/Have You] Make These Mistakes in [Subject]? The warning formula, immortalized by the famous "Do You Make These Mistakes in English?" — one of the longest-running ads in history. The magic word is *these*: it points at specific mistakes you can't see yet, welding fear of error to a curiosity gap. The reader clicks not to buy, but to check themselves.

4. Give Me [Short Time] and I'll [Deliver Outcome]. A dramatized bargain: a tiny, concrete commitment traded for a large, concrete result. "Give Me Five Days and I'll Give You a Magnetic Personality." The formula works because it prices the reader's risk in *time*, which feels safer to spend than money — and the speaker's confidence is itself a proof signal.

5. They Laughed When [Low-Status Moment] — But When [Turn]! The story formula (see **Finding Your Angle**): humiliation, pivot, implied triumph, cut off at the peak. Use it whenever your product creates a visible before/after that others witness.

6. Warning: [Danger Relevant to Reader]. The pattern-interrupt. "Warning" is one of the few words that borrows institutional authority — it's the vocabulary of safety labels, not salesmen. Must be followed by a danger the body copy genuinely substantiates, or the borrowed authority converts to broken trust.

7. The Secret of [Desirable Outcome]. Pure mechanism-tease (see **Curiosity: Withholding the How**): asserts a specific piece of withheld knowledge stands between the reader and the outcome. "The Secret of Making People Like You." Wears out fastest of all the formulas — "secret" is heavily spent vocabulary — so it demands an unusually fresh subject.

8. [Number] Ways to [Outcome] / [Number] Mistakes That [Cost]. The list formula. The number makes the promise concrete and finite (a known, skimmable commitment), and odd or specific numbers out-pull round ones ("76 Reasons Why It Would Have Paid You..." — see **Believability and Proof**).

9. At Last / Announcing / New: [Development]. The news formula. Frames the product as an event, and gives the long-suffering reader permission to hope again — "at last" implies the wait (and their past failures) weren't their fault.

Notice what the nine reduce to: benefit, social proof, warning, bargain, story, curiosity, specificity, news. That's the real lesson. When you can name the pattern under a formula, you can write headlines that follow no formula at all.

The Swipe File: Your Real Education

A **swipe file** is a personal, organized collection of proven advertising you study — the working copywriter's textbook. Every master kept one. The reasoning is blunt: headlines that ran for years in paid media *ran because they were paying*. A famous control that survived a decade of testing contains more verified persuasion knowledge than any theory book.

Collect. Save ads you see repeatedly over weeks or months — repetition in paid media is the signal that something is working. Save classics (the ads quoted throughout this series are the start of a canon). Save headlines that stopped *you*, even outside your market; your own reaction is data.

Organize by pattern, not by product. File by which principle a headline runs on — benefit lead, curiosity gap, warning, proof-heavy, story — and note which of the three surfaces it lived on. A swipe file sorted by industry teaches you what other niches say; sorted by pattern, it teaches you how persuasion works.

Study, don't skim. For each keeper, annotate the same three questions used throughout this series: *Anatomy* (what parts is it built from?), *Why It Works* (which psychological pattern carries it?), *Funnel Fit* (which surface, which commitment?). Ten headlines analyzed this way teach more than a thousand collected.

Swipe the structure, never the words. This is the ethical and practical line. Copying a headline verbatim is theft, and it also doesn't work — the original was calibrated to its market, moment, and product. What you take is the *skeleton*: the mistake-tease of "Do You Make These Mistakes...", the time-bargain of "Give Me Five Days..." — re-fleshed entirely with your market's specifics. If someone who knows the original would call yours a copy, you've swiped too shallow.

Three Classic Swipes, Annotated

SWIPE

"Do You Make These Mistakes in English?" (a famous classic that ran for decades)

ANATOMY [Direct Question] + ["These" Pointing at Unseen Specifics] + [Everyday Competence Area].

WHY IT WORKS It weaponizes self-doubt about a skill everyone uses publicly every day, and "these" creates a gap only the copy can close. The reader self-tests; the ad merely holds the mirror. Decades of paid repetition are the proof it kept working.

FUNNEL FIT Ad — a self-check question is a one-second, high-relevance scroll-stopper.

SWIPE

"How to Win Friends and Influence People" (Dale Carnegie's title — perhaps the most successful "how to" ever)

ANATOMY [How To] + [Deep Social Desire] + [Second Compounding Desire].

WHY IT WORKS Two universal wants — belonging and influence — joined so naturally the reader hears one seamless promise. There's no cleverness, no curiosity trick, no adjectives: just instruction offered toward outcomes nearly every human privately wants more of. Proof that at maximum benefit-clarity, plain beats clever.

FUNNEL FIT Advertorial — "how to" promises an education, which is what an editorial read delivers.

SWIPE

"Who Else Wants a Screen-Star Figure?" (a famous classic)

ANATOMY [Who Else] + [Vivid Aspirational Image].

WHY IT WORKS "Else" smuggles in a crowd of satisfied users without citing one, and "screen-star figure" is a benefit the reader can see rather than parse. Question form makes the reader answer — and a "yes, me" is the click.

FUNNEL FIT Ad — self-selecting question, instant image, zero explanation needed.

Three Angle-Built Swipes, Annotated

Headlines are angles wearing words (see **Finding Your Angle**). These three classics show recurring angle families executed as finished headlines — study how the doorway underneath shapes every word choice.

SWIPE

"Brisbane Local Jane Mathews Stumbles Across A Natural Arthritis Relief Solution"

ANATOMY [Geographic Anchor] + [Named Everywoman] + [Accidental Discovery] + [Benefit Category].

WHY IT WORKS Three angle families stacked — Local (Brisbane), Story (Jane, a specific person), Discovery ("stumbles across," which removes sales intent: she wasn't selling anything, she just *found* it). Reads like community news, not advertising.

FUNNEL FIT Ad — the local-news register is built for a native feed.

SWIPE

"They Laughed When I Sat Down at the Piano — But When I Started to Play!" (a famous 1920s ad)

ANATOMY [Social Humiliation] + [Pivot Dash] + [Implied Triumph].

WHY IT WORKS Perhaps the most imitated story angle ever written. It compresses a complete transformation arc into one sentence and stops at the exact peak of the turn, forcing the reader into the copy to see the ending. The reader isn't buying piano lessons; they're buying the moment the laughter stops.

FUNNEL FIT Advertorial — it's the first line of a story the page then tells in full.

SWIPE

"Small Company's New Golf Ball Flies Too Far; Could Obsolete Many Golf Courses" (a famous classic)

ANATOMY [Underdog Source] + [Benefit Disguised as a Problem] + [Absurd Institutional Consequence].

WHY IT WORKS Discovery + Contrarian in one line. The benefit (distance) is framed as *too much of a good thing* — a complaint — which flips the sales pitch into news and makes the claim feel like a leak rather than an ad.

FUNNEL FIT Ad — the news register and the "wait, what?" flip are engineered for cold scrollers.

Fictional Before/After: Filling a Formula vs. Wearing It

Imagine you're promoting a fictional posture-training wearable, the AlignBand.

Before (formula filled mechanically):

Technically a "how to." But the blank was filled with generic category words — "fix," "fast" — so the skeleton shows through and reads as advertising wallpaper.

After (same formula, market-calibrated flesh):

How Desk Workers Are Undoing 'Laptop Hunch' — Without Exercises, Reminders, or a Single Chiropractor Visit

Still the "how to" pattern (with the "without [dreaded cost]" variant). But now it's fleshed with the audience (desk workers), a named, recognizable pain ("laptop hunch"), and negations of the three fixes the reader has already tried and abandoned. The formula gave the draft its shape; the market gave it its words.

■ Calibrating Formulas Across the Three Surfaces

Formulas are surface-agnostic skeletons — the calibration is in which you reach for, and how loudly.

- **Ad — question, warning, and news skeletons.** Cold readers respond to self-check questions ("Do You Make These Mistakes..."), warnings, and news frames — the formulas that read as content, not commerce. Keep the fill editorial and platform-clean.
- **Advertorial — story and "how to" skeletons.** The read is best sold by formulas that promise narrative or instruction: "They Laughed When...", "How to...", "The Secret of..." — shapes that a long editorial page can actually deliver on.
- **Jump page — bargain and promise skeletons.** This is a second ad for a one-click reader, so reach for compressed, confident structures that still sell: "Give Me [90 Seconds] and I'll Show You..." pointed straight at the play button — a time-bargain plus the loop the ad opened, aimed at the video. Keep the curiosity the reader arrived with; just don't open a new, unrelated mystery.

✓ Key Takeaways

- Formulas are fossilized psychology: learn them to internalize the patterns (benefit, proof, warning, bargain, story, curiosity, specificity, news), then outgrow them.
- Master the nine skeletons — from "How to..." and "Who Else Wants..." to the warning, the time-bargain, and the numbered list.
- Build a swipe file: collect ads proven by paid repetition, organize by pattern and surface, and annotate each with Anatomy / Why It Works / Funnel Fit.
- Swipe the structure, never the words — refill every skeleton with your market's specific audience, pain, and mechanism.
- Match skeleton to surface: content-like shapes at the ad, narrative and instruction shapes at the advertorial, compressed bargain-and-promise shapes at the jump page.